

WEEDING

Weeds make your garden look messy and can be hard to control. But in addition to being unsightly, they also compete with your crops for water, nutrients, light, and space, often harboring pests and diseases. It's vitally important to keep them under control.

THE NEED TO WEED

Annual weeds, such as speedwell and chickweed, can be controlled by hoeing. Slice weed stems just below the soil surface. Be careful to do this before they flower or they will create a fresh generation of seed. Preferably, weed on a dry day so that the sun will dry out and kill any upturned roots.

Perennial weeds, such as bindweed and brambles, are much harder to destroy. To remove them completely you will need to dig out every trace of root or rhizome from the soil, or they will regenerate. Do this diligently, as soon as you see weeds reshooting and you will win the battle eventually, but on a very overgrown patch you may want to use a chemical weedkiller. Use protective clothing and a mask, and spray carefully to prevent it from reaching nearby crops.

MULCHING

A mulch is a layer of material spread around the base of a plant that can serve a number of useful purposes in the fruit or vegetable garden. Black plastic sheeting or old carpet can be used to warm the ground, trap moisture, or suppress weeds by depriving them of light. Mulching with compost and manure improves soil structure and boosts it with vital nutrients. Using a straw mulch helps by raising crops such as strawberries or zucchini out of the mud, allowing air to circulate beneath them, and keeping them out of the path of pests such as slugs. See individual growing guides for details on mulching specific crops.



Protect strawberries with a straw mulch.